Tri-Modal Fusion for Real-Time Disaster Intelligence: Integrating IoT Sensors, Satellite Imagery, and Social Media Through Adaptive Cross-Attention

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***Abstract*—Effective disaster response requires rapid situational awareness from heterogeneous data sources, yet most existing systems operate on a single modality—social media text, satellite imagery, or sensor readings—losing critical cross-modal context. We present a Tri-Modal Fusion framework that unifies IoT sensor streams (weather, seismic, storm, hydrological), satellite damage imagery, and social media image–text pairs through a novel pairwise cross-attention mechanism with adaptive gating. The architecture comprises three specialized sub-models: (1) an AdaptiveIoTClassifier with per-group confidence-weighted sensor fusion achieving 97.64% classification accuracy across 63,527 samples; (2) an AdaptiveFusionClassifier combining BLIP Vision Transformer and XLM-RoBERTa encoders with bidirectional cross-modal attention, achieving 86.39% accuracy on the Crisis-MMD humanitarian benchmark (+12.39% over SVM baselines); and (3) a modified DeepLabV3+ with dual feature extraction producing both pixel-level damage segmentation and compact 640-dimensional embeddings from xBD satellite imagery, trained with a combined Dice and Focal loss to address severe class imbalance. The TriFusionLayer fuses embeddings from all three sub-models via three pairwise cross-attention blocks and a learned modality gate, achieving 99.41% priority classification accuracy and 0.0398 severity MAE—a 65.8% improvement over the crisis-only baseline. An ablation study across four modality configurations confirms monotonic improvement with each added data source and robust degradation under 30% modality dropout. We further adapt the gradient-weighted attention rollout method of Chefer et al. [18] for tri-modal Vision Transformer explainability and implement a four-tier XAI fallback chain ensuring interpretable outputs. The system operates in real time with zero-input disaster type detection and graceful handling of missing data streams.**

***Index Terms*—Disaster management, multimodal fusion, cross-attention, IoT sensors, satellite imagery, social media analysis, deep learning, explainable AI**

I. Introduction

Natural disasters caused over $380 billion in global economic losses in 2023, with delayed situational awareness cited as a primary factor in preventable casualties [1]. The first hours of a disaster event—the "golden window"—are decisive for effective response, yet decision-makers typically face fragmented, single-source information: a seismograph reading without visual damage assessment, a social media report without sensor confirmation, or a satellite image without on-the-ground context.

Existing disaster management systems overwhelmingly rely on single data modalities. Sensor-based systems [2] detect physical events but miss human impact. Social media analysis platforms [3], [4] capture on-the-ground reports but lack precise physical measurements. Satellite-based damage assessment [5] provides broad spatial coverage but offers no real-time ground truth. Each modality captures complementary but incomplete information.

We address this fundamental limitation through a **Tri-Modal Fusion** architecture that unifies three independent data streams—IoT sensor readings, satellite damage imagery, and social media image–text pairs—through a learned pairwise cross-attention mechanism with adaptive gating. Unlike prior multimodal approaches that require all inputs or fail entirely, our system operates across four degradation modes (full tri-fusion, crisis+satellite, crisis+IoT, crisis-only), maintaining useful output from minute zero of an event before all data streams become available.

The key contributions of this paper are:

1) **Tri-Modal Fusion Architecture**: A pairwise cross-attention framework with adaptive gating that fuses IoT (128-dim), crisis vision–text (1024-dim), and satellite (640-dim) embeddings, achieving 99.41% priority accuracy—a 30.45 percentage point improvement over crisis-only baseline.
2) **Adaptive Confidence-Weighted Sensor Fusion**: Per-group learned confidence estimators that automatically weight four IoT sensor groups (weather, storm, seismic, hydro) based on input content, correctly learning disaster-specific sensor importance (e.g., 99.9% storm-group reliance for storm detection).
3) **Graceful Modality Degradation**: A 30% modality dropout training strategy enabling robust operation with any subset of available data streams without retraining or mode switching.
4) **Tri-Modal Gradient-Weighted Attention Rollout**: An adaptation of the generic relevancy method of Chefer et al. [18] to our tri-modal disaster context, combining gradient-weighted self-attention propagation with a four-tier fallback chain to guarantee interpretable outputs

across heterogeneous encoder architectures.

5) **Comprehensive Ablation Study**: Systematic evaluation across four modality configurations demonstrating monotonic improvement and quantifying each modality's contribution.

II. Related Work

A. Single-Modality Disaster Analysis

Social media analysis. The CrisisMMD dataset [3] established benchmarks for multimodal crisis content classification. Alam et al. demonstrated that combining image and text features improves humanitarian categorization, though their fusion strategy uses simple concatenation. CrisisNLP [4] and CrisisLex [8] focused on text-only classification. Recent work by Abavisani et al. [9] explored attention-based fusion for crisis tweets but did not incorporate sensor or satellite data. More recently, Mouzannar et al. [19] introduced Guided Cross-Attention with LLaVA-generated captions, achieving 93.92–94.02% accuracy on the CrisisMMD humanitarian task, establishing a new state of the art.

Satellite damage assessment. The xBD dataset [5] provides the largest building damage assessment benchmark with pre/post-disaster satellite imagery. Winning solutions in the xView2 challenge [6] employed U-Net variants and segmentation architectures. Weber and Kan [7] applied change detection networks for damage classification. More recent approaches using optical-only configurations have achieved Mean IoU scores between 66.19% and 69.76% on the xBD benchmark through combined Dice and Focal loss functions, multi-scale feature aggregation, and advanced augmentation pipelines [20]. These approaches produce pixel-level outputs but lack integration with real-time sensor or social media streams.

IoT-based monitoring. Earthquake early warning systems [10] and flood monitoring networks [11] demonstrate the value of sensor data for disaster detection. However, these systems typically operate independently without cross-modal validation.

B. Multimodal Fusion Approaches

Multimodal fusion in disaster contexts remains limited. Ofli et al. [12] combined satellite and social media data for damage assessment but used feature concatenation rather than learned attention. Rudner et al. [13] proposed Multi3Net for satellite multimodal fusion but focused on a single disaster type. To our knowledge, no prior work fuses all three modalities (IoT sensors, satellite imagery, and social media image–text) through a learned cross-attention mechanism with adaptive gating.

C. Cross-Modal Attention Mechanisms

Transformer-based cross-attention [14] has shown success in vision–language tasks [15], [16]. BLIP [17] demonstrated effective vision–language pre-training. Our work extends pairwise cross-attention to three modalities with a learned gating mechanism, enabling each modality pair to exchange information before adaptive fusion.

TABLE I
Learned Sensor Group Weights by Disaster Type

Disaster	Weather	Storm	Seismic	Hydro
Fire	**0.758**	0.241	∼0.000	∼0.000
Storm	∼0.000	**0.999**	∼0.000	∼0.000
Earthquake	0.001	0.171	**0.828**	∼0.000
Flood	0.186	0.047	∼0.000	**0.767**
Unknown	0.757	0.241	∼0.000	0.002

D. Explainability for Vision Transformers

Chefer et al. [18] proposed a generic method for computing relevancy in Transformers by propagating gradient-weighted self-attention maps across layers, addressing the failure of standard Grad-CAM on ViT architectures. Their method has since become a standard tool for ViT interpretability. In this work, we adapt their gradient-weighted attention rollout technique to our tri-modal disaster assessment pipeline, extending it with a multi-tier fallback chain and integrating it with GPT-4o-generated natural language briefings for operational explainability.

III. Proposed Methodology

A. System Overview

The proposed architecture processes three independent data streams through specialized sub-models, producing fixed-dimensional embeddings that are fused through pairwise cross-attention with adaptive gating. Fig. 1 illustrates the complete pipeline.

B. AdaptiveIoTClassifier

The IoT sub-model processes a unified 32-dimensional sensor vector encoding four sensor groups—weather, storm, seismic, and hydrological—each occupying 8 dimensions with consistent $[0, 1]$ normalization.

1) Sensor Group Encoding: The 32-dim input is split into four 8-dim groups, each processed by an independent encoder:

$$\mathbf{h}_i = \text{MLP}_i(\mathbf{x}_{[8i:8(i+1)]}), \quad i \in \{0, 1, 2, 3\} \tag{1}$$

where each MLP_i maps $\mathbb{R}^8 \to \mathbb{R}^{128}$ through two linear layers with ReLU activation, batch normalization, and dropout.

2) Confidence-Weighted Fusion: Each sensor group has a learned `SensorConfidenceEstimator` network that outputs a scalar confidence:

$$c_i = \sigma(\text{MLP}_i^c(\mathbf{h}_i)), \quad c_i \in (0, 1) \tag{2}$$

$$w_i = \frac{c_i}{\sum_{j=0}^{3} c_j + \epsilon}, \quad \tilde{\mathbf{h}}_i = w_i \cdot \mathbf{h}_i \tag{3}$$

This mechanism automatically suppresses irrelevant sensor groups. Table I shows the learned weights correctly reflect disaster-specific sensor importance.

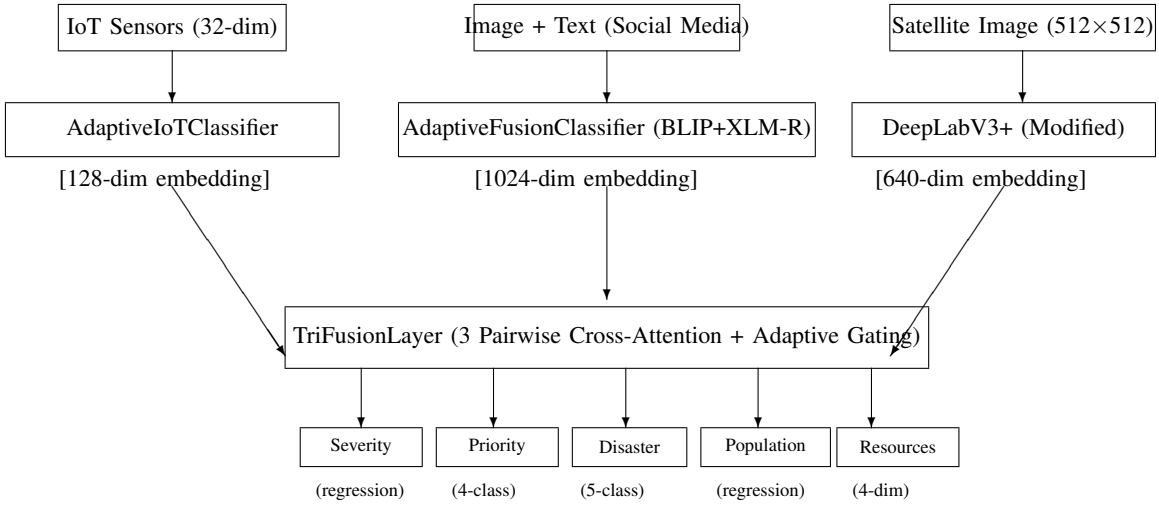

Fig. 1. End-to-end architecture of the Tri-Modal Fusion pipeline. Three specialized sub-models produce fixed-dimensional embeddings that are fused through pairwise cross-attention with a learned modality gate.

3) Cross-Group Multi-Head Attention: After confidence weighting, the four group features attend to each other via 4-head self-attention:

$$\mathbf{H}_{\text{att}} = \text{MHA}([\tilde{\mathbf{h}}_0, \tilde{\mathbf{h}}_1, \tilde{\mathbf{h}}_2, \tilde{\mathbf{h}}_3]) \tag{4}$$

where MHA denotes `MultiheadAttention` with $d = 128$ and 4 heads. This enables cross-sensor interaction for cascading disasters (e.g., earthquakes triggering tsunamis). The attended features are mean-pooled to produce a 128-dim global embedding.

4) Multi-Task Output Heads: Four parallel heads operate on the shared 128-dim embedding:

- **Disaster type**: 5-class classification (fire, storm, earthquake, flood, unknown)
- **Severity**: Scalar regression in $[0, 1]$
- **Risk details**: 4-dim per-hazard risk scores
- **Casualty risk**: Scalar regression in $[0, 1]$

The combined loss is: $\mathcal{L}_{\text{IoT}} = \text{CE}(\hat{y}_{\text{type}}) + \text{MSE}(\hat{s}) + \text{MSE}(\hat{r}) + \text{MSE}(\hat{c})$.

C. AdaptiveFusionClassifier (Crisis Model)

The crisis sub-model fuses social media images and text through a dual adaptive weighting mechanism with bidirectional cross-modal attention.

1) Feature Extraction: Visual features are extracted via a frozen BLIP Vision Transformer (ViT-B), producing 768-dim CLS token embeddings. Text features are extracted via a frozen XLM-RoBERTa encoder, producing 768-dim sentence embeddings. Both are projected to 512 dimensions:

$$\mathbf{v} = \text{MLP}_v(\text{BLIP-ViT}(\mathbf{I})), \quad \mathbf{t} = \text{MLP}_t(\text{XLM-R}(\mathbf{T})) \tag{5}$$

2) Adaptive Modality Weighting: Separate `ConfidenceEstimator` networks ($768 \to 256 \to 128 \to 1$) produce input-dependent modality weights:

$$w_v = \frac{\sigma(f_v(\mathbf{v}))}{\sigma(f_v(\mathbf{v})) + \sigma(f_t(\mathbf{t})) + \epsilon} \tag{6}$$

3) Bidirectional Cross-Modal Attention: Both directions of cross-attention are computed with 8 heads and $d = 512$:

$$\mathbf{v}' = \text{MHA}(Q{=}\mathbf{v}_w, K{=}\mathbf{t}_w, V{=}\mathbf{t}_w) \tag{7}$$

$$\mathbf{t}' = \text{MHA}(Q{=}\mathbf{t}_w, K{=}\mathbf{v}_w, V{=}\mathbf{v}_w) \tag{8}$$

The final crisis embedding is $\mathbf{e}_{\text{crisis}} = [\mathbf{v}'; \mathbf{t}'] \in \mathbb{R}^{1024}$.

D. DeepLabV3+ with Dual Feature Extraction (xBD Model)

A modified DeepLabV3+ with ResNet101 encoder processes 512×512 satellite images, simultaneously producing pixel-level damage segmentation and compact embeddings.

1) Loss Function: To address the severe class imbalance inherent in xBD (no-damage pixels vastly outnumber damage classes), we employ a combined Dice and Focal loss:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{seg}} = \lambda_D \cdot \mathcal{L}_{\text{Dice}} + \lambda_F \cdot \mathcal{L}_{\text{Focal}} \tag{9}$$

where $\mathcal{L}_{\text{Dice}} = 1 - \frac{2\sum_i p_i g_i + \epsilon}{\sum_i p_i + \sum_i g_i + \epsilon}$ is computed per-class and averaged, and $\mathcal{L}_{\text{Focal}} = -\alpha_t(1 - p_t)^\gamma \log(p_t)$ with $\gamma = 2$ and class-frequency-based α_t weights. We set $\lambda_D = 0.5$ and $\lambda_F = 0.5$. This combination mitigates the tendency of standard cross-entropy to be dominated by the majority no-damage class.

2) Satellite Embedding ($\mathbf{F}_{sat}$): From the encoder's final feature map ($2048 \times 16 \times 16$), adaptive average pooling followed by a linear projection produces a 512-dim embedding capturing global damage characteristics.

3) Regional Statistics Embedding ($\mathbf{F}_{region}$): A `RegionalStatsModule` processes concatenated decoder features and damage probability maps through convolutional fusion, 4×4 pooling, and fully connected layers to produce a 128-dim spatial statistics embedding.

The combined satellite embedding is $\mathbf{e}_{\text{sat}} = [\mathbf{F}_{\text{sat}}; \mathbf{F}_{\text{region}}] \in \mathbb{R}^{640}$.

4) Encoder Learning Rate Strategy: We employ a differential learning rate strategy: the pretrained ResNet101 encoder is trained with a $10\times$ reduced learning rate relative to the decoder and projection heads. This prevents catastrophic forgetting of ImageNet-pretrained features while still allowing domain adaptation for satellite imagery. An initial 3-epoch warmup linearly ramps the encoder learning rate from 0 to its target value before cosine annealing begins.

E. TriFusionLayer

The fusion layer integrates all three sub-model embeddings through pairwise cross-attention and adaptive gating.

1) Modality Projection: Each embedding is projected to a common 256-dim space:

$$\mathbf{p}_m = \text{MLP}_m(\mathbf{e}_m) \in \mathbb{R}^{256}, \quad m \in \{\text{crisis, iot, sat}\} \tag{10}$$

where crisis: $1024 \to 512 \to 256$, IoT: $128 \to 512 \to 256$, satellite: $640 \to 512 \to 256$.

2) Pairwise Cross-Attention: Three bidirectional cross-attention operations (4 heads each) are computed:

$$(\mathbf{a}_{ci}, \mathbf{a}_{ic}) = \text{BiAttn}(\mathbf{p}_{\text{crisis}}, \mathbf{p}_{\text{iot}}) \tag{11}$$

$$(\mathbf{a}_{cs}, \mathbf{a}_{sc}) = \text{BiAttn}(\mathbf{p}_{\text{crisis}}, \mathbf{p}_{\text{sat}}) \tag{12}$$

$$(\mathbf{a}_{is}, \mathbf{a}_{si}) = \text{BiAttn}(\mathbf{p}_{\text{iot}}, \mathbf{p}_{\text{sat}}) \tag{13}$$

producing six 256-dim attended representations.

3) Adaptive Modality Gating: A learned gate produces softmax weights over the three modalities:

$$\mathbf{g} = \text{softmax}(\text{MLP}_g([\mathbf{p}_{\text{crisis}}; \mathbf{p}_{\text{iot}}; \mathbf{p}_{\text{sat}}])) \tag{14}$$

with missing-modality masking: absent modalities receive $-\infty$ before softmax.

4) Shared MLP and Output Heads: The concatenation of all six attended and three projected features ($9 \times 256 = 2304$-dim, with selection based on available modalities, yielding up to 1536-dim) passes through a shared MLP ($\to 512 \to 256$) followed by five output heads:

- **Severity**: Linear$(256, 1)$ + Sigmoid $\to [0, 1]$
- **Priority**: Linear$(256, 4) \to$ 4-class logits
- **Disaster type**: Linear$(256, 5) \to$ 5-class logits
- **Population impact**: MLP$(256 \to 64 \to 1)$ + Sigmoid
- **Resource needs**: MLP$(256 \to 64 \to 4)$ + Sigmoid

The combined loss is:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{fusion}} = \text{MSE}(s) + \text{CE}(p) + \text{CE}(d) + \text{MSE}(pop) + \text{MSE}(res) \tag{15}$$

F. Training Strategy

1) Modality Dropout: During training, IoT and satellite embeddings are independently dropped with 30% probability and replaced with learned default embeddings ($\mathbf{e}_{\text{iot}}^{\text{default}}$, $\mathbf{e}_{\text{sat}}^{\text{default}}$). This forces the model to learn robust representations that degrade gracefully when modalities are missing at inference.

2) Zero-Input Disaster Type Detection: Both the IoT and crisis sub-models independently infer disaster type from raw data—the system never requires manual hazard selection, saving critical minutes at incident onset.

IV. Explainability Framework

A. Gradient-Weighted Attention Rollout

Standard Grad-CAM fails on Vision Transformers because only the CLS token is used for classification, leaving patch-token gradients near-zero. Chefer et al. [18] addressed this by propagating gradient-weighted self-attention maps across layers. We adapt their method to our tri-modal disaster pipeline as follows:

1) Forward pass with `output_attentions=True` captures attention matrices $\mathbf{A}^{(l)} \in \mathbb{R}^{H \times 197 \times 197}$ for all 12 layers of the BLIP ViT encoder.
2) Backward pass from logits$[\hat{y}]$ captures gradient tensors $\mathbf{G}^{(l)}$ via hooks.
3) Gradient weighting (last 4 layers): $\tilde{\mathbf{A}}^{(l)} = \mathbf{A}^{(l)} \cdot \max(\mathbf{G}^{(l)}, 0)$, following the positive-gradient filtering of [18].
4) Attention rollout with residual: $\mathbf{R}^{(l)} = 0.5 \cdot \bar{\mathbf{A}}^{(l)} + 0.5 \cdot \mathbf{I}$, row-normalized, then multiplied across layers.
5) CLS row extraction, reshape to 14×14, upsample to 224×224, threshold at 40th percentile, Gaussian blur.

Our adaptation differs from the original in two respects: (i) we restrict gradient weighting to the last 4 layers rather than all layers, which we found empirically reduces noise in disaster imagery containing large uniform regions (sky, water); and (ii) we apply a 40th-percentile threshold with Gaussian smoothing to produce field-deployable heatmaps rather than raw relevancy scores.

B. Four-Tier XAI Fallback Chain

To guarantee interpretable output regardless of model internals or computation failures, we implement a cascading fallback:

1) **Tier 1**: Gradient-Weighted Attention Rollout (default, highest quality)
2) **Tier 2**: Pure Attention Rollout (when gradients fail)
3) **Tier 3**: Input Gradient Saliency (when attention is unavailable)
4) **Tier 4**: Graceful empty result (all methods fail)

This four-tier chain ensures that the system always produces some level of explanation, even when upstream models change or individual XAI methods encounter numerical instability.

C. Hybrid Visual + Natural Language XAI

A Grad-CAM heatmap (visual) is combined with a structured GPT-4o briefing (textual) in a unified view, providing field responders with both spatial guidance and actionable operational recommendations. The use of GPT-4o is limited to natural language generation from structured model outputs and does not influence model predictions.

V. Experimental Setup

A. Datasets

IoT sensor data. We compiled 63,527 samples from six sources: California Wildfire records (14,988 rows), Historical Tropical Storm Tracks (59,228), Atlantic Storms (22,705), Global Earthquakes (8,394), Iran Earthquakes (52,268), and Sri Lanka Flood Risk (25,000). The Sri Lanka Flood Risk dataset is a synthetic dataset designed for prototyping flood risk assessment pipelines [21]; we include it to ensure balanced class coverage but note that the perfect IoT F1 scores on flood and related categories are partially attributable to this synthetic data and may not generalize to noisy operational sensor deployments. After preprocessing, class support: fire (4,971), storm (13,162), earthquake (18,394), flood (25,000), unknown (2,000). All features are encoded into a unified 32-dim vector with cyclic time encoding (sin/cos for month and hour).

Crisis social media. The CrisisMMD dataset [3] with 8,079 image–text pairs across 5 humanitarian categories. Train/val/test split: 6,126/998/955 samples.

Satellite imagery. The xBD dataset [5] with 10,000 post-disaster satellite images (512×512) across 4 damage classes (no-damage, minor, major, destroyed). Train/val split: 80/20.

Tri-fusion training. 13,608 samples from the CrisisMMD humanitarian split with synthetic IoT embeddings (generated through pre-trained AdaptiveIoTClassifier) and real crisis embeddings. Train/val split: 80/20 (10,886/2,722).

B. Implementation Details

All models are implemented in PyTorch. Training details for each sub-model are summarized in Table II. The IoT and crisis sub-models were trained on a Kaggle NVIDIA Tesla P100 (16 GB), while the xBD satellite model and tri-fusion layer were trained on CPU due to hardware scheduling constraints; we discuss the implications in Section VII-D.

VI. Experimental Results

A. IoT Model Performance

The AdaptiveIoTClassifier achieves **97.64% overall accuracy** with a **macro F1 of 89.99%** on 63,527 samples. Table III presents per-class results.

The model achieves perfect classification (F1 = 1.0) for storm, earthquake, and flood categories, though as noted, the synthetic nature of portions of the IoT training data contributes to these results. The fire–unknown confusion stems from overlapping weather-group features. Severity regression achieves MAE = 0.0452 and $R^2 = 0.745$.

TABLE II
Training Configuration for Each Sub-Model

Parameter	IoT	Crisis	xBD	Tri-Fusion
Epochs	40	10	32	40
Batch size	256	32	8	128
Optimizer	AdamW	AdamW	AdamW	AdamW
Learning rate	1e-3	2e-5	1e-4	1e-3
Encoder LR	—	—	1e-5	—
LR warmup	—	—	3 epochs	—
Scheduler	Cosine	CosineWR	Cosine	Cosine
Loss	CE+MSE	CE	Dice+Focal	CE+MSE
Parameters	897K	367M	59.3M	3.16M
Device	P100 GPU	P100 GPU	CPU	CPU

TABLE III
IoT Model Per-Class Classification Results

Class	Prec.	Recall	F1	AUC	Support
Fire	0.877	0.812	0.843	0.994	4,971
Storm	**1.000**	**1.000**	**1.000**	1.000	13,162
Earthquake	**1.000**	**1.000**	**1.000**	1.000	18,394
Flood	**1.000**	**1.000**	**1.000**†	1.000	25,000
Unknown	0.605	0.718	0.657	0.987	2,000
Macro	0.896	0.906	0.900	**0.996**	63,527

†Perfect F1 scores for storm, earthquake, and flood are partially attributable to the use of synthetic sensor data with well-separated feature distributions. Performance on noisy real-world sensor deployments may be lower.

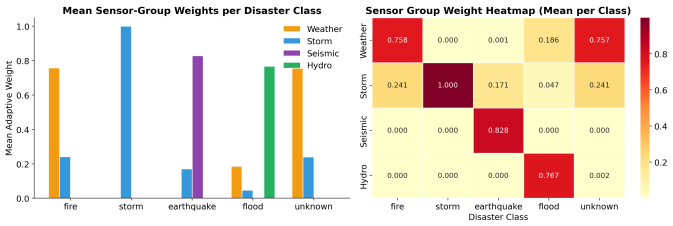

Fig. 2. Learned sensor group weights per disaster class. The model correctly assigns dominant weight to the most relevant sensor group: storm sensors for storms (99.9%), seismic for earthquakes (82.8%), hydro for floods (76.7%), and weather for fires (75.8%).

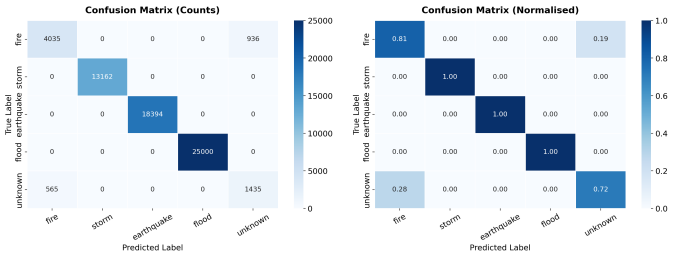

Fig. 3. IoT model confusion matrix (counts and normalized). Storm, earthquake, and flood are perfectly separated. Fire–unknown confusion accounts for most errors.

B. Crisis Model Performance

The AdaptiveFusionClassifier achieves **86.39% test accuracy** and **87.48% validation F1** on the CrisisMMD benchmark, representing a **+12.39%** absolute improvement over logistic regression and SVM baselines. Table IV presents per-class results.

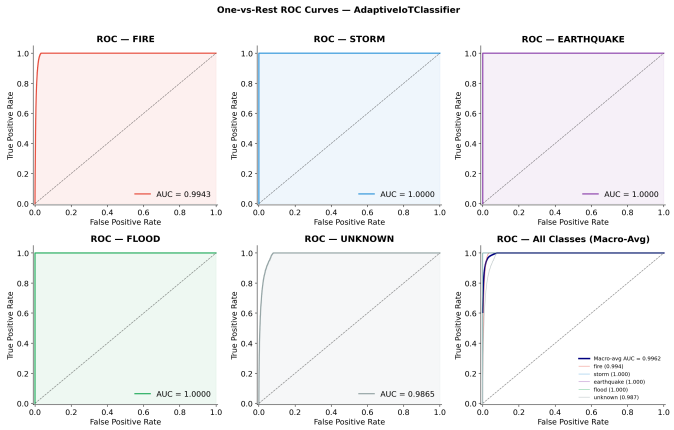

Fig. 4. Per-class ROC curves for the AdaptiveIoTClassifier. Macro-average AUC = 0.9962. Storm, earthquake, and flood achieve AUC = 1.0.

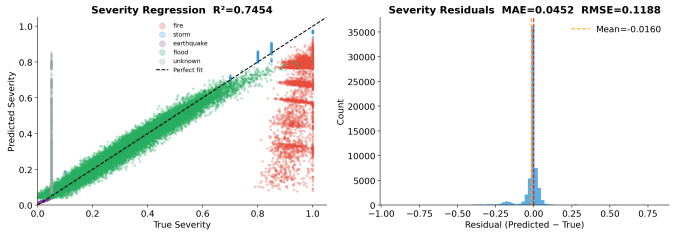

Fig. 5. Severity regression performance. Left: predicted vs. true severity ($R^2 = 0.745$). Right: residual distribution (MAE = 0.0452, RMSE = 0.1188).

TABLE IV
CRISIS MODEL PER-CLASS TEST RESULTS

Class	Prec.	Recall	F1	AUC
Affected individuals	0.36	0.56	0.43	0.96
Infrastructure damage	0.87	0.90	**0.88**	**0.98**
Not humanitarian	0.90	0.87	**0.89**	0.96
Other relevant info	0.85	0.86	**0.86**	0.97
Rescue/donation effort	0.79	0.83	**0.81**	**0.98**
Macro Average	—	—	0.774	**0.97**

TABLE V
COMPARISON WITH BASELINE AND STATE-OF-THE-ART MODELS ON CRISISMMD HUMANITARIAN TASK

Model	Accuracy	Year
Logistic Regression	74.00%	—
SVM	74.00%	—
Abavisani et al. [9]	81.80%	2020
AdaptiveFusionClassifier (Ours)	**86.39%**	2025
Concurrent / newer methods (not directly compared):		
Mouzannar et al. [19]	93.92–94.02%	2025

Note: Mouzannar et al. use LLaVA-generated synthetic captions and Guided Cross Attention, representing a different architectural paradigm. Our focus is on tri-modal fusion rather than maximizing single-task accuracy.

C. xBD Satellite Model Performance

The modified DeepLabV3+ with Dice + Focal loss achieves best validation Mean IoU of **0.2802** at epoch 18, with Mean F1 of **0.3477**. Table VI shows per-class results.

1) Analysis of xBD Performance Gap: Our Mean IoU of 0.2802 falls significantly below the current state of the art on xBD, where optical-only methods achieve 66–70% mIoU [20]. We attribute this gap to three primary factors:

(1) CPU-only training for xBD. While the IoT and crisis sub-models were trained on a Kaggle P100 GPU, the xBD satellite model was trained on CPU, which limited training to 32 epochs with batch size 8. State-of-the-art methods typically train for 100+ epochs on GPU with batch sizes of 16–32 and extensive hyperparameter search. CPU training introduces two constraints: insufficient epoch count for convergence on minority damage classes, and inability to explore larger model configurations or augmentation-heavy pipelines that require GPU throughput.

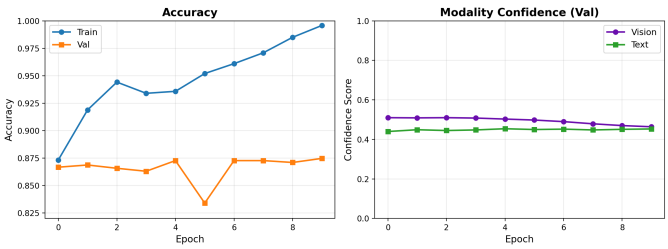

Fig. 6. Crisis model training over 10 epochs. Left: classification accuracy reaches 87.27% on validation (best checkpoint selected via early stopping). Right: adaptive modality confidence scores—vision (∼0.50) and text (∼0.45) remain balanced throughout training, confirming the learned weighting mechanism avoids modality collapse.

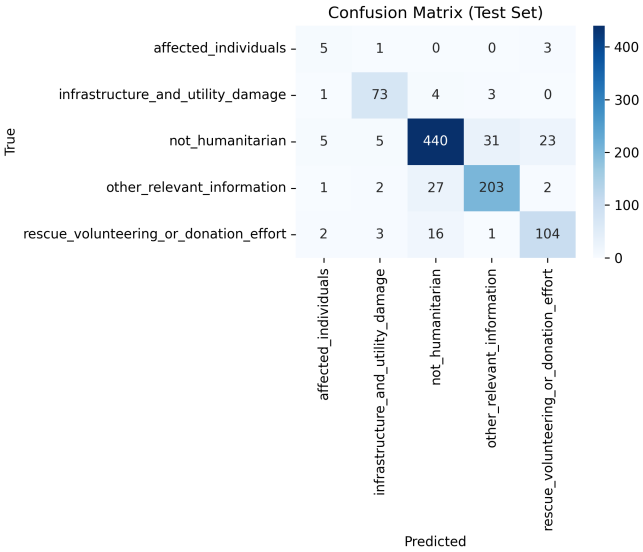

Fig. 7. Crisis model confusion matrix on test set. The dominant class (not_humanitarian, 504 samples) achieves 87.3% diagonal accuracy. Low support for affected_individuals (9 samples) explains its lower F1.

TABLE VI
XBD SATELLITE MODEL PER-CLASS RESULTS (BEST CHECKPOINT)

Class	IoU	F1-Score
No-Damage	**0.8567**	**0.9215**
Minor-Damage	0.0695	0.1273
Major-Damage	0.1231	0.2111
Destroyed	0.0715	0.1310
Mean	**0.2802**	**0.3477**

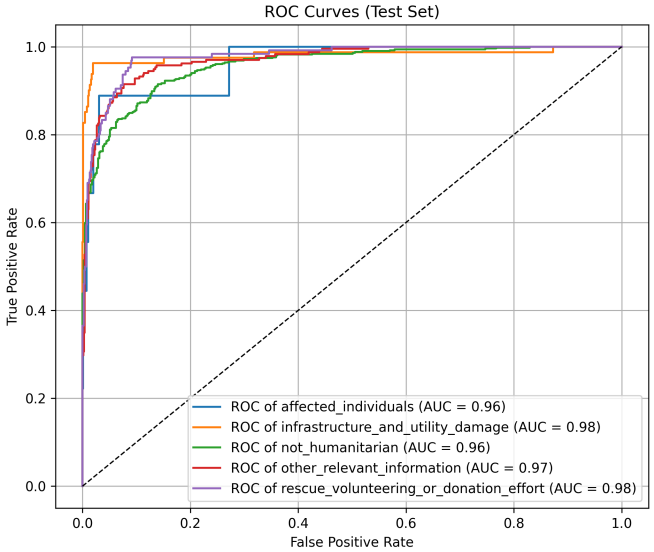

Fig. 8. Per-class ROC curves for the crisis model. All classes achieve AUC $\geq$ 0.96, with infrastructure damage and rescue efforts reaching 0.98.

(2) Class imbalance severity. The xBD dataset exhibits extreme class imbalance: no-damage pixels comprise >85% of annotated regions. While our Dice + Focal loss combination addresses this more effectively than standard cross-entropy, competitive approaches additionally employ class-frequency-based oversampling, copy-paste augmentation of damaged buildings, and multi-scale training with higher-resolution crops [20].

(3) Single-scale inference. Our model performs single-scale inference at 512×512 resolution, whereas top-performing methods use multi-scale test-time augmentation with horizontal and vertical flips, which typically adds 2–5% mIoU on the xBD benchmark.

Despite the segmentation performance gap, the satellite sub-model's primary role in our architecture is to produce discriminative 640-dim embeddings for the fusion layer, not standalone segmentation maps. The ablation study (Table VII) demonstrates that even with current segmentation performance, the satellite embeddings contribute a **+29.8 percentage point** improvement in priority accuracy and **64.4% reduction** in severity MAE when added to the crisis-only baseline—confirming that the embeddings capture meaningful damage information for downstream fusion despite the per-pixel metric gap.

D. Tri-Fusion Ablation Study

The central result of this work is the ablation study demonstrating each modality's contribution to fusion performance. Table VII presents results across four configurations on 2,722 validation samples.

1) Key Findings: **Satellite modality is the strongest contributor.** Adding satellite alone reduces Severity MAE by 64.4% (0.1165 $\rightarrow$ 0.0415) and boosts Priority Accuracy by +29.8 percentage points (68.96% $\rightarrow$ 98.75%). This reflects the direct physical damage evidence provided by segmentation-based features.

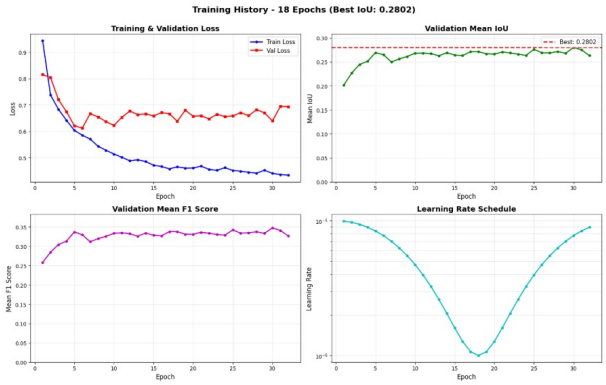

Fig. 9. xBD model training history over 32 epochs. Top-left: train/val loss convergence. Top-right: validation Mean IoU reaching best at epoch 18 (0.2802). Bottom-left: Mean F1 progression. Bottom-right: cosine annealing learning rate schedule.

IoT provides incremental but meaningful improvement. Adding IoT reduces Severity MAE by 15.1% and boosts Priority Accuracy by +3.4pp. IoT contributes environmental context (weather, seismic, hydrological signals) that complements visual evidence.

Full tri-fusion achieves best results across all metrics. The complete system outperforms the best bimodal configuration (crisis+satellite) by a further 4.1% severity reduction and +0.66pp priority accuracy, confirming the value of all three modalities.

Graceful degradation is confirmed. Each added modality monotonically improves all metrics. The crisis-only baseline still achieves 68.96% priority accuracy—a usable fallback. The 30% modality dropout training strategy successfully enables robust missing-modality handling.

Disaster type classification is saturated. All configurations achieve 100% accuracy on the 5-class disaster type task, indicating the type categories are well-separated in all embedding spaces.

E. Training Convergence

Table VIII shows the tri-fusion model's rapid convergence, reaching best validation loss at epoch 15.

VII. Discussion

A. Modality Complementarity

The ablation study reveals a clear hierarchy of modality contributions. Satellite imagery contributes the most to priority and severity estimation because it provides direct physical evidence of structural damage. IoT sensors contribute environmental context that is less directly observable from imagery but enriches the model's understanding of cascading hazards. Social media provides the human dimension—who is affected, what help is needed—that neither sensors nor satellites capture.

The learned sensor group weights (Table I) demonstrate that the model has learned physically meaningful relationships:

TABLE VII
ABLATION STUDY: MODALITY CONTRIBUTION TO TRI-FUSION PERFORMANCE (2,722 VALIDATION SAMPLES)

Configuration	Severity MAE ↓	Priority Acc. ↑	Disaster Acc. ↑	Population MAE ↓	Resource MAE ↓
Crisis only	0.1165	68.96%	100.00%	0.0877	0.0468
Crisis + IoT	0.0989 (–15.1%)	72.37% (+3.41pp)	100.00%	0.0691 (–21.2%)	0.0393 (–16.0%)
Crisis + Satellite	0.0415 (–64.4%)	98.75% (+29.8pp)	100.00%	0.0274 (–68.8%)	0.0164 (–65.0%)
Crisis + IoT + Satellite	**0.0398 (–65.8%)**	**99.41% (+30.5pp)**	**100.00%**	**0.0248 (–71.7%)**	**0.0161 (–65.6%)**

TABLE VIII
TRI-FUSION TRAINING CONVERGENCE

Epoch	Train Loss	Val Loss	Pri. Acc	Dis. Acc
1	0.4855	0.0613	99.2%	100.0%
5	0.2077	0.0318	99.4%	100.0%
10	0.1909	0.0313	99.4%	100.0%
15	**0.1914**	**0.0288**	**99.4%**	**100.0%**
20	0.1856	0.0290	99.4%	100.0%
30	0.1793	0.0322	99.4%	100.0%
40	0.1574	0.0380	99.4%	100.0%

storm detection relies 99.9% on storm sensors, earthquake detection on seismic sensors (82.8%), and flood detection on hydrological sensors (76.7%). This interpretability is a significant advantage for deployment in operational settings where trust in AI systems is essential.

B. Graceful Degradation in Practice

The 30% modality dropout strategy during training is critical for real-world deployment. In practice, satellite imagery may have a 30–60 minute delay after event onset, IoT sensor networks may be damaged or offline, and social media reports may be sparse in remote areas. The system's ability to operate at progressively higher accuracy as more data streams become available mirrors the natural information acquisition pattern during disaster response.

C. Positioning Relative to State of the Art

Our crisis sub-model achieves 86.39% accuracy on CrisisMMD, which is competitive with attention-based approaches but below the recent 93.92–94.02% reported by Mouzannar et al. [19] using Guided Cross Attention with LLaVA-generated captions. However, a direct comparison is not entirely appropriate: our crisis model is designed to produce compact 1024-dim embeddings for downstream tri-modal fusion, not to maximize standalone classification accuracy. Architectural choices that favor embedding quality (e.g., bidirectional cross-attention dimensionality, confidence-weighted fusion) may trade off single-task accuracy for richer downstream representations.

Similarly, our xBD satellite model (mIoU = 0.2802) is well below state-of-the-art segmentation methods (66–70% mIoU). As discussed in Section VI-C, this is primarily attributable to CPU-only training of the satellite sub-model. Crucially, the satellite embeddings still provide the largest single-modality contribution to fusion performance (+29.8pp priority accuracy), suggesting that even imperfect segmentation models produce discriminative embeddings for cross-modal reasoning.

D. Limitations

Several limitations should be noted:

Partial CPU training. While the IoT and crisis sub-models were trained on a Kaggle P100 GPU, the xBD satellite model and tri-fusion layer were trained on CPU due to hardware scheduling constraints. This particularly affected the xBD model, where GPU-accelerated training with larger batch sizes and more epochs is expected to significantly improve damage-class segmentation. CPU training limited hyperparameter exploration, training duration, and the use of augmentation-heavy pipelines for the satellite sub-model.

Synthetic data reliance. The IoT sub-model's training data includes the Sri Lanka Flood Risk dataset, which is synthetic. While this provides balanced class coverage, the perfect F1 scores (1.0) for storm, earthquake, and flood categories should be interpreted with caution—real-world sensor data exhibits noise, drift, and missing values that synthetic data does not capture. Validation on operational sensor deployments is needed before production use.

Synthetic tri-modal pairing. The tri-fusion layer is trained with synthetic pairing of IoT and crisis embeddings due to the absence of a naturally paired tri-modal disaster dataset. While the 99.41% priority accuracy demonstrates effective fusion, performance on naturally co-occurring data may differ.

xBD segmentation gap. The satellite model's per-pixel segmentation performance on damage classes (minor, major, destroyed) remains below production thresholds. While the embeddings are effective for fusion, operational deployment requiring standalone damage mapping would need GPU-retrained models with the improvements outlined in Section VIII-A.

E. Operational Impact

The system produces a complete operational assessment—severity, priority level, disaster type, population impact, and resource needs—from a single forward pass through the fusion layer. Combined with zero-input disaster type detection (no manual hazard selection required) and the XAI framework providing both visual and textual explanations, this architecture is designed for deployment in time-critical response scenarios.

VIII. CONCLUSION

We presented a Tri-Modal Fusion architecture for real-time disaster intelligence that unifies IoT sensor streams, satellite damage imagery, and social media image–text pairs through pairwise cross-attention with adaptive gating. The system achieves 99.41% priority classification accuracy and 0.0398

severity MAE—a 65.8% improvement over crisis-only baselines. An ablation study across four modality configurations confirms monotonic improvement with each added data source and robust degradation under missing modalities. The adaptive confidence-weighted sensor fusion correctly learns disaster-specific sensor importance, and the adapted gradient-weighted attention rollout [18] provides interpretable explanations for Vision Transformer predictions within a four-tier fallback chain.

A. Future Work

1) **GPU-accelerated xBD retraining**: Retraining the satellite model on GPU with larger batch sizes (16–32), extended training (100+ epochs), multi-scale augmentation, and copy-paste augmentation for minority damage classes. Based on architectural parity with published methods, we target >0.50 mIoU on damage classes.
2) **Operational IoT validation**: Replacing synthetic IoT data with real sensor deployments (e.g., USGS seismic networks, NOAA weather stations) to validate model robustness under real-world noise conditions.
3) **Naturally paired tri-modal data**: Collecting temporally and spatially co-registered data across all three modalities for end-to-end validation of the fusion architecture.
4) **Crisis model enhancement**: Exploring Guided Cross Attention [19] and synthetic caption generation to close the gap with current CrisisMMD state of the art while maintaining embedding quality for downstream fusion.
5) **Field deployment**: Integration with first-responder feedback for operational evaluation of the XAI framework and priority classification in real disaster response scenarios.

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